

DECODED EXPLAINED

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Railways needs to decongest its busiest routes; how multitracking could help

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THE INDIAN Railways (IR), often called India's lifeline for its passenger-carrying capacity, is also among the world's largest freight transportation systems. The freight revenues — accounting for over 65% of IR's total earnings — subsidise passenger travel.

The expansion of National Highways has led to IR facing competition in freight transportation. Although freight transport via rail is cheaper and environmentally sustainable, the congestion across the network and inadequate last-mile connectivity are major roadblocks in utilising its full potential.

To resolve this, IR has now taken up multitracking — four lines instead of two — on all its seven high density networks (HDNs), which account for over 40% of its traffic. It is also expediting its third dedicated freight corridor (DFC) connecting Dankuni (West Bengal) to Surat (Gujarat).

High density network

HDNs are the passenger-freight corri-

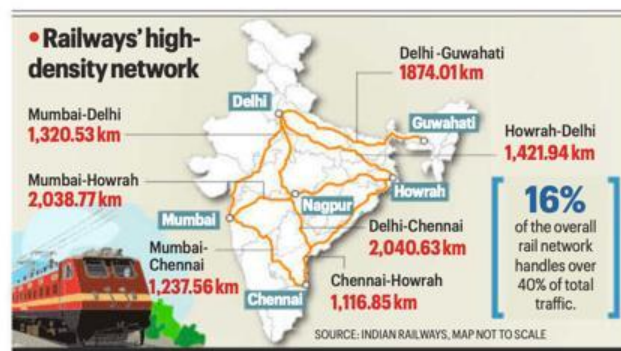
dors where the number of trains are running beyond its capacity in most of the sections. For instance, in the 28-km Karjat-Lonavala section near Mumbai, an average 67 trains run each way daily against the maximum capacity of 40. This overutilisation causes congestion, delays in passenger and freight trains and affects the overall efficiency of the network.

Of the 69,000-plus km network of the Indian Railways, the seven HDNs add up to 11,051 km, or almost 16% of the total. These corridors are also considered IR's backbone, as they handle over 40% of the total traffic (see chart).

According to IR, HDNs should operate at 70-80% of total capacity to avoid congestion. Data, however, shows that only 4.6% of the networks are operating below 80% capacity. So, congestion occurs frequently in sections, which leads to the delay in train arrival, mostly the freight trains. The average speed of freight trains is still only 25 kmph.

Multitracking

The multitracking of these sections are



important not only for passenger convenience but increasing freight loading as well. IR's model share in India's freight transportation is around 27%, and it carried 1,670 million tonnes freight in 2025-26. It has set an ambitious target to increase its loading to 3,000 million tonnes by 2030.

To achieve this, HDNs have to be converted to normal routes. According to the National Rail Plan, if multitracking of HDNs is not taken up, the line-capacity utilisation by 2031 of 50% of the network will be over 150%, 39% will see 100-150% utilisation, and 9% of sections will operate

at 70-100% of capacity. The Union Cabinet recently approved eight multitracking projects spanning 1,196 km worth Rs 20,804 crore. Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw said that multitracking will not only decongest HDNs but also reduce India's logistics cost. He noted that about 2,000 km of these routes was already four-line.

Freight corridors

Freight corridors are special lines for goods trains. In some sections, they run parallel to the HDNs while in others they take a detour to bypass passenger terminals. The idea of Eastern and Western DFCs came about because of the oversaturation of the existing trunk routes — Howrah-Delhi on the eastern corridor and Mumbai-Delhi on the western corridor — with line capacity utilisation varying between 115% and 150%.

Now, both the corridors are fully operational and see running of an average 420 freight trains per day. The Eastern DFC runs from Ludhiana (Punjab) to Sonnagar (Bihar), and caters mostly to coal and mineral traffic from eastern India. Traffic on the western

corridor mainly comprises ISO containers — standardised steel shipping boxes built to move goods safely across ships, trains, and trucks without unloading the cargo — from JNPT and Mumbai Port in Maharashtra, and Pipavav, Mundra and Kandla ports in Gujarat, headed for Inland Container Depots located in north India, mostly at Tughlakabad (Delhi), Dadri (UP), Dhandari Kalan (Punjab) and Khatuwas (Rajasthan).

IR is now moving ahead with the construction of the proposed 1,738-km East-West DFC from Dankuni to Surat. The major traffic generators on the section are coal mines, iron ore, bauxite, manganese, steel plants, ports, fertilisers, FCI godowns, etc.

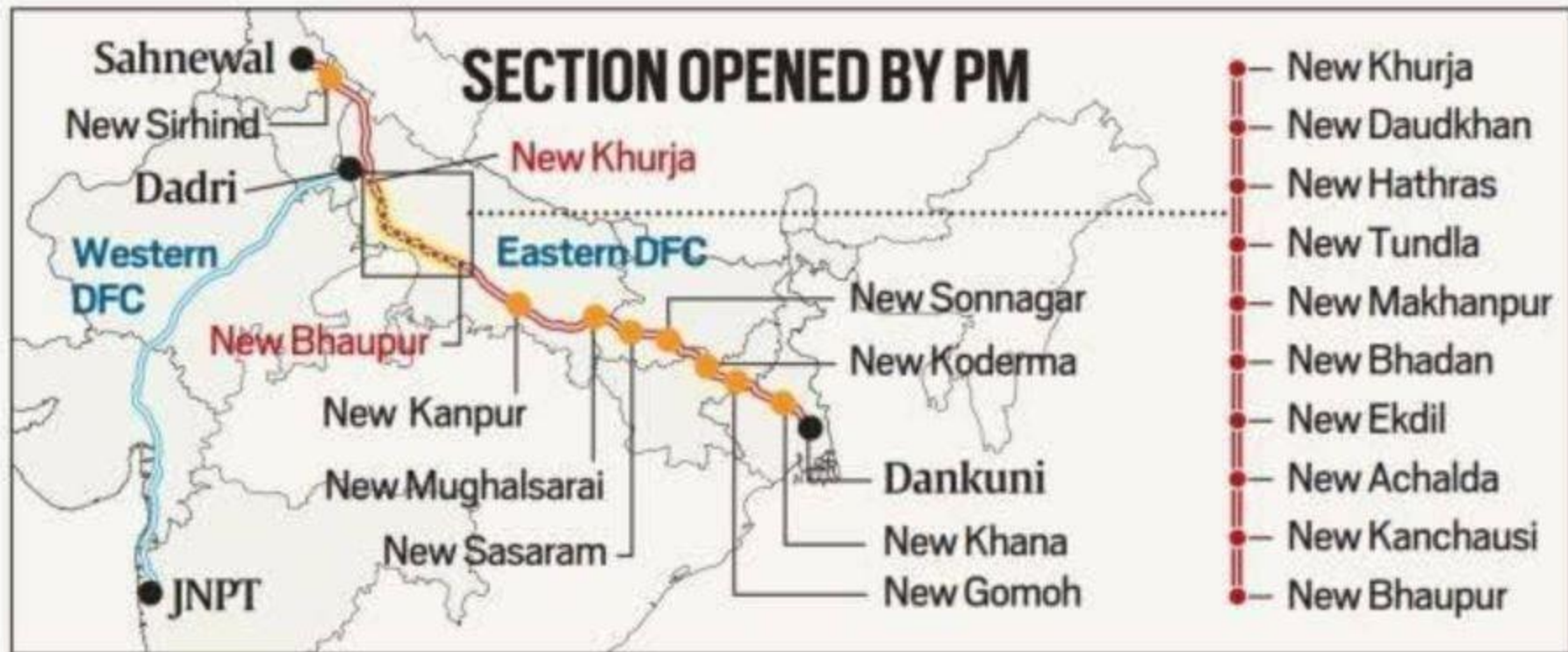
There are two more such projects in the pipeline: the East Coast corridor from Kharagpur (West Bengal) to Vijayawada (Andhra Pradesh), running parallel to the existing Kharagpur-Vijayawada coastal railway line; and North-South corridor from Itarsi (Madhya Pradesh) to Vijayawada via Nagpur. These projects, however, have not yet been sanctioned and might be taken up in the future.

Eastern Dedicated Freight Corridor (EDFC): Runs 1,337 km from Ludhiana (Punjab) to Sonnagar (Bihar), carrying coal, steel, and food grains.

Western Dedicated Freight Corridor (WDFC): Runs 1,506 km from Dadri (Uttar Pradesh) to Jawaharlal Nehru Port Terminal (JNPT) in Mumbai, handling double-stack containers

The **2026 Union Budget** announced a **2,052-km Dankuni-Surat East-West DFC**, and its DPR preparation/updating is underway.

SECTION OPENED BY PM



Hog in the limelight

The survival of the pygmy hog depends on a thriving ecosystem

The decline of the **pygmy hog** – the sole surviving species of the genus *Porcula* and the world's smallest wild suid – is a narrative about the decline of India's alluvial floodplains. The pygmy hog depends significantly on dense grasslands to feed, conceal itself, and reproduce, so distress among these animals is an indicator of the floodplain suffering degradation. Protecting the pygmy hog can also extend protections to threatened species such as the Bengal florican, hispid hare, hog deer, and greater one-horned rhinoceros. The Assam government was recently right to laud the efforts of a captive breeding programme that increased the pygmy hog population in the State 32-fold in the last three decades. Breeding from a small founder stock while preventing diseases – suids are highly susceptible to swine diseases – and inbreeding requires conservationists to track pedigree, follow biosafety protocols, and condition individuals before release. That said, the species' survival in the wild depends on the survival of specific ecosystems, and the latter remains a work in progress. The pygmy hog was believed to be extinct by the mid-20th century as floodplains were converted for farms, tea plantations, and flood control infrastructure and were degraded by invasive plants and altered flood cycles, with the unscientific burning of grasslands further fragmenting habitats. A few individuals were rediscovered in 1971, prompting one conservation effort. The current efforts are due to the **Pygmy Hog Conservation Programme** from 1995.

Even now, the difficulty of spotting and counting these animals means that it is hard to say how many exist in the wild; per the Durrell Wildlife Conservation Trust, there were some 250 individuals in early 2025, with the last surviving natural population in the Panbari grasslands area of the Manas National Park. Since they continue to be threatened, the captive individuals form the insurance group, but even so, the group's long-term evolutionary fitness is still not guaranteed. Researchers are also alert to the accumulation of harmful gene variants in the population and low genetic diversity, and thus look forward to the pygmy hog's natural habitats being restored. Alluvial floodplains are dynamic ecosystems; in addition to threats such as land conversion, efforts to 'save' them, such as widespread dry-season fires, can still destroy the dense cover the pygmy hog needs. On the other hand, suppressing ecological processes can leave trees and shrubs to turn grassland into woodland. Given the plan to increase the wild pygmy hog population to 300 by 2040, Assam needs to revert the fragmentation of its protected grasslands, especially in Rupai and Kanchanbari, and to restore buffer zones around the Manas and Orang National Parks and the Sonai Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary.

Pygmy Hog- world's smallest wild suid
Alluvial flood plains, Grassland ecosystem

Need for landscape-level conservation: Long-term recovery requires restoring grassland mosaics, maintaining habitat corridors and managing floodplain ecosystems alongside continued population monitoring and genetic management

Genetic management +
habitat restoration +
natural selection = long-term evolutionary viability



PYGMY HOG

Porcula salvania

FOUND IN
Grasslands of
Assam's Manas
National Park and
Orang National Park

NUMBERS IN WILD

Less than
350
as per Pigmy Hog
Conservation
Programme

CONSERVATION STATUS

Endangered under
IUCN Red List

MAJOR THREATS

Grassland
degradation due to
uncontrolled grass
burning, illegal
cattle grazing, rapid
habitat succession

India remains at 131st rank in global gender parity index

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI/GENEVA

India retained the 131st rank on the Global Gender Gap Index 2026 released by the World Economic Forum on Wednesday, with Iceland, Finland and Norway maintaining their top three slots respectively.

The 14 countries ranked below than India on the index include Papua New Guinea, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Tajikistan, Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Morocco, Mali, Algeria, and Congo.

Chad was the lowest-ranked country in the index, with Iran and Pakistan joining it in the bottom three.

For India, the progress towards gender parity stood at 64.5%, below the global average. While India's score improved slightly over the last year, its global ranking remained unchanged at 131st.

India retains 131st rank on WEF's Global Gender Gap Index 2026, with its gender parity score (64.5) still below the global average of 69.2%

Four Key Dimensions & Scores

Economic Participation and Opportunity (61.7% parity): Assesses labour-force participation, wage equality, earned income, and leadership/technical roles.

Educational Attainment (96.9% parity): Evaluates literacy rates and enrolment ratios in primary, secondary, and tertiary education

Health and Survival (96.2% parity): Measures the sex ratio at birth and healthy life expectancy

Political Empowerment (22.1% parity): Examines the ratio of women to men in parliamentary seats, ministerial positions, and heads of state.

Scoring Scale

Scores range from **0 to 1** (0% to 100%), with **1 (100%)** indicating complete parity and **0 (0%)** indicating total inequality.

FCNR(B) deposits saved India from a BoP deficit in July

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

India's balance of payments (BoP) received a significant boost in July 2026 as non-resident Indian (NRI) deposits under the FCNR(B) scheme surged to \$33.5 billion, accounting for a substantial share of the country's capital account surplus during the month.

The capital account surplus widened to \$27.7 billion in July 2026, nearly eight times the \$3.5 billion recorded in July 2025. Dollar-denominated bank deposits from NRIs contributed to most of this.

Without the RBI's special scheme, NRI deposits would have remained at their usual monthly level of \$1 billion. Combined with a \$15 billion outflow in other bank capital, this would have pushed the capital account into a \$4.8 billion deficit. When added to the \$7 billion current account deficit, India's overall BoP would have faced an \$11.8 billion deficit, which would have marked the third month of deficit had it not been for FCNR

(B) deposits.

RBI's special deposit scheme attracted \$127 billion in NRI deposits, with more than 26% of the inflows recorded in July 2026. This helped keep the capital account in a \$27.7 billion surplus and the overall BoP at a \$20.8 billion surplus during the reporting month.

"FCNR(B) inflows and more of External Commercial Borrowings (ECB) inflows for a few more months kept the current month and the whole fiscal year comfortable for the balance of payment. This can be a one time comfort and may not be available next year," said Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist of Bank of Baroda.

Focussing on FDI is the crux and FII outflows should slow down and turn positive for the capital account to be in a self-sustaining surplus, he said. Given the global conditions, it may be difficult for significant inflows of FII or FDI to come in. This can mean a continued pressure on the foreign exchange reserves, Mr. Sabnavis added.

India's **Balance of Payments (BoP)** is divided into the **Current Account** and the **Capital Account**, tracking all cross-border economic transactions and changes in foreign assets and liabilities

Current Account Components

The Current Account records day-to-day trade in goods, services, income, and unilateral transfers without creating direct foreign assets or liabilities.

- Merchandise Trade** Exports and imports of physical goods.

Determines the merchandise trade balance

- Services Trade (Invisibles)** IT and software services. Travel, tourism, and transportation

- Primary Income** Investment income (dividends, interest).

Compensation of employees across borders

- Secondary Income** Private remittances from overseas workers. Official grants, gifts, and foreign aid.

Capital Account Components

tracks financial flows that alter a nation's foreign assets and external liabilities.

- Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)** Inbound or outbound long-term equity capital. Establishes lasting management control in enterprises

- Foreign Portfolio Investment (FPI)** Investments in foreign stocks and debt instruments. Does not confer direct management control

- External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs)** Commercial loans raised by domestic firms from abroad. External assistance or sovereign loans.

- Non-Resident Indian (NRI) Deposits** Foreign currency deposits held by diaspora in India.

- Changes in Foreign Exchange Reserves** Buffer assets managed by the Reserve Bank of India.

Full Cuppa

NRI deposits saved the BoP position from a deficit and is expected to keep it that way for the rest of the fiscal year

Month	Balance of payments actual*	Balance of payments assuming FCNR(B)* flows were same as April to June levels	
April 2026 P	-6.6	-6.6	
May 2026 P	-4.4	-4.4	
June 2026 P	2.9	2.9	P: provisional
July 2026 P	20.8	-11.8	* figures in \$ billion Source: RBI



Thank you

“The price of success is daily effort”



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